

HUMANS IN FLIGHT - REAL STORIES OF REFUGEES AND NEWCOMERS

INTRODUCTION:

Humans in Flight is a project that showcases the inspiring stories of individuals who have had to flee their homelands and find new lives in Canada. These stories not only document their incredible journeys but also celebrate their resilience and contributions. Beyond being a mere collection of stories, Humans in Flight is a platform with a human touch, with a mission to shatter stereotypes, build bridges of understanding, and stand up for refugee people. We aim to amplify the voices of remarkable individuals, nurturing empathy, sparking action, and paving the way for a more embracing and caring society.

PROJECT GOALS:

The primary goals of the Humans in Flight project are:

1. Challenge stereotypes and political discourse surrounding refugee people, emphasizing their talents, gifts, resilience, and resourcefulness.
2. Celebrate the contributions of refugees to Canada, including their artistic and cultural offerings, highlighting their strength and resourcefulness.
3. Promote and recognize multiculturalism as a cornerstone of Canadian society, fostering social cohesion and unity.
4. Foster empathy among Canadians by sharing personal stories and artwork of refugees, helping them better understand the challenges faced by asylum seekers and refugee people.

METHODS AND STRATEGIES:

1. The Humans in Flight project employs the following methods and strategies:
2. Photography and storytelling: Humanizing the stories of refugees through visual storytelling.
3. Instagram and website presence: Utilizing popular social media platforms to engage with a diverse audience, particularly younger demographics.

ACTIVITIES AND TASKS:

The project encompasses essential activities and tasks:

1. **Photo documentation:** Capturing visually appealing images that showcase the lives, talents, and contributions of refugees.
2. **Narrative collection:** Gathering personal narratives from newcomers to provide an in-depth view of their experiences.

3. **Reels:** Creating short videos conveying important messages shared by profile subjects.
4. **Content creation:** Pairing photos with narratives to create engaging content for Instagram.

IMPLEMENTATION PLAN:

The project's implementation plan includes:

1. **Project team:** Assembling a dedicated team of photographers, writers, and social media managers.
2. **Community engagement:** Establishing partnerships with local refugee support organizations and communities for inclusivity.

RESOURCE ALLOCATION:

Resources for the project will cover:

1. **Photography equipment and services:** Budgeting for equipment and professional photographers.
2. **Social media management:** Allocating resources for content creation and audience engagement.

CONCLUSION:

Humans in Flight is a transformative initiative that seeks to reshape the perceptions of refugees and newcomers in Canada. By using photography, storytelling, and a strong online presence, we aim to promote empathy, celebrate contributions, and strengthen multicultural bonds. The project contributes to creating a more inclusive and compassionate Canada.

FOUNDER'S MESSAGE: MY JOURNEY AND INSPIRATION FOR HUMANS IN FLIGHT

I am honored to share my journey with the CANConnect Diversity Micro-grants for Immigrant Youth and Refugee Youth, as it aligns seamlessly with the mission and vision of our project, Humans in Flight.

I was born in Myanmar, and I belong to the Rohingya minority, a group that has endured severe persecution and genocide for decades. However, due to the escalating conflict in Rakhine state, I was forced to leave my homeland and seek refuge in Indonesia.

As a refugee, I experienced firsthand the dehumanizing treatment that refugee people often endure. This experience fueled my determination to become a catalyst for change and raise awareness about the plight of marginalized refugee people and asylum seekers.

I discovered that one of the most powerful tools for awareness of crises like refugees is sharing the stories of refugees and giving them a platform to express their voices. I noticed that many

media outlets often only allowed refugees to share a portion of their stories within the framework of their interests, leading to misinformation and biased reporting.

Having published numerous articles in media outlets like [Al Jazeera](#), [BBC](#), [CBC](#), and many other outlets, I came to realize that the most effective way to raise awareness about the circumstances faced by displaced people is by providing a platform that amplifies the voices of refugees and asylum seekers. This realization led me to co-found "[The Archipelago](#)," a literary magazine that redefines the discourse on migration, decolonization, and more.

Upon arriving in Canada, I became involved in various advocacy activities, including speaking at schools and events while volunteering as an advisor and consultant with [Northern Lights Canada](#).

Recently, I am offered a fellowship opportunity by the Parliamentary Centre under the Young Leader for Inclusive Democratic Future of Myanmar program. Through this program, I raised awareness of Rohingya refugees' suffering in Bangladesh and refugee crises mostly in Asia. However, I realized that, even in Canada, the dynamics of the refugee crisis were not always well understood due to trust issues with media communication.

INSPIRATION FOR HUMANS IN FLIGHT:

With the aim of addressing this gap, I conceived the idea of launching a project using social media platforms such as Instagram, Facebook, and a website. This platform would allow refugees, newcomers, sponsors, helpers, and volunteers to share their stories and inspire Canadians and people worldwide to make a positive difference regarding the refugee crisis.

With the support of friends in Toronto, including refugee advocates and newcomers, I initiated this project. Despite our limited resources as newcomers, we managed to temporarily set up a free Google site, create an Instagram account, and establish a Facebook page. We published a few stories, including our own, and those of my sponsors, volunteers, and helpers. However, due to limited support and equipment, I have been unable to take this project to the next level.

We aspire to broaden the platform to include a broader mosaic of Canadian voices, encompassing LGBTQ2S+, Aboriginal, more women, and members of other ethnic communities. Since coming to Carleton University studying global Migration and Transnationalism, I've been delighted to see such a wide range of people from different backgrounds, and I hope that Humans in Flight could be a valuable asset to our local community, both for raising awareness and deepening the ties between us.

FIND US AT:

Website: <https://www.humansinflight.org/>

Instagram: https://www.instagram.com/humans_in_flight/

Facebook: <https://www.facebook.com/profile.php?id=100087897227350>

Thank you for your support.

Together, we can make a positive impact.